New password not accepted on a remote laptop: syncing cached credentials

Article KB0010003 | Owner: Service Desk L1 | Subcategory: Password reset | Applies to: Windows 11 laptops (Dell Latitude 5440/7440, Lenovo ThinkPad T14/X1 Carbon, HP EliteBook 840)

Summary

When a user resets their Windows password via the self-service portal but still cannot log in on a remote laptop, the issue is usually caused by out-of-date cached credentials. The laptop must connect to the corporate network (VPN or ACME-Corp Wi-Fi) so the new password can be synchronized with the local credential cache. This article guides users through verifying connectivity, forcing a credential update, and clearing stale entries, and provides service-desk steps for verification and escalation.

Symptoms

- Logon screen displays 'The username or password is incorrect.'
- After entering the new password, the prompt reappears immediately.
- Credential Manager shows an entry for 'ACME-Corp' with an outdated password.
- Repeated failed attempts trigger account lockout after five tries.

Common causes

- Cached domain credentials on the laptop have not been updated after a password reset.
- The device is not connected to the corporate network (VPN or ACME-Corp Wi-Fi) when the user attempts to log on.
- A stale credential stored in Windows Credential Manager interferes with the authentication attempt.
- Intermittent connectivity prevents the device from reaching a domain controller to validate the new password.

Overview

When a password is changed through Azure AD self-service password reset (SSPR), the new credential is stored only in the cloud directory. A Windows laptop that is off-network continues to use the locally cached version of the old password until it can reach a domain controller or refresh its cache via a network logon. If the laptop cannot contact a domain controller, the logon prompt rejects the new password and may show a generic 'username or password incorrect' message. Connecting to the VPN or the ACME-Corp Wi-Fi network allows the machine to validate the new password against Azure AD (through hybrid join) and update the cached credentials. Clearing any stale entries in Credential Manager removes conflicting data that can cause the logon UI to revert to the old password.

Self-Help Procedure: Sync Cached Credentials

Follow these steps if you have already reset your password through https://passwordreset.acme.example and you are unable to log in on your remote laptop. Ensure you have the new password handy and that you can establish a VPN connection before proceeding.

1. Connect to the corporate VPN by opening the GlobalProtect client and signing in with your Azure AD credentials (use MFA push or SMS). Verify that the client shows 'Connected' and that you can reach internal resources such as the intranet home page.
2. If VPN is not available, connect to the ACME-Corp Wi-Fi network using your laptop's 802.1X settings; you will be prompted for your Azure AD username and password - enter the new password here.
3. Lock the workstation (Windows?+?L) and then unlock it. At the unlock screen, enter the new password you just set. The system should now accept it and log you on.
4. If the logon still fails, open Credential Manager: search for 'Credential Manager' in the Start menu, choose 'Windows Credentials', look for any entry that mentions 'ACME-Corp', 'vpn.acme.example', or your username, and select 'Remove'.
5. After removing the stale entry, repeat the lock/unlock step (Windows?+?L, then unlock) and log on with the new password.
6. Once you are successfully logged on, verify that you can access mapped drives or internal web sites to confirm the VPN/Wi-Fi connection is still active.

Service Desk Agent Procedure

When a user reports that a newly reset password is not accepted on a remote laptop, verify identity, confirm the password reset succeeded, and guide the user through network connectivity and credential cache clearance. Use the following steps to resolve the issue efficiently.

1. Confirm the user's identity using the standard verification protocol (ask for employee ID, date of birth, or recent ticket number).
2. Check the SSPR portal logs or ask the user to confirm they received the password reset confirmation email and that the new password meets complexity requirements (14+ characters, not in last 10).
3. Instruct the user to connect to the GlobalProtect VPN (portal vpn.acme.example) using their Azure AD username and the new password, completing MFA push or SMS verification.
4. If VPN connection fails, have the user switch to the ACME-Corp Wi-Fi network, ensuring the laptop's 802.1X profile is configured for machine certificate authentication.
5. Once connected, ask the user to lock (Windows?+?L) and unlock the laptop, entering the new password at the prompt.
6. If logon still fails, remotely guide the user to open Credential Manager, delete any cached Windows credentials related to ACME-Corp, VPN, or their username, then repeat the lock/unlock step.
7. After successful logon, request the user to test access to an internal resource (e.g., https://intranet.acme.example) to confirm the session is fully authenticated.

Verification and Closure

After the user reports a successful logon, perform final checks to ensure the issue is resolved and document the outcome. This helps prevent repeat tickets and provides useful data for trend analysis.

1. Ask the user to lock and unlock the laptop one more time using the new password to confirm consistency.
2. Verify that the user can access internal file shares, Outlook on the web, and Teams without being prompted for credentials again.
3. Check the Event Viewer (Windows Logs > Security) for Event ID 4624 (successful logon) correlated with the timestamp of the last logon attempt; note the authentication package (Negotiate, Kerberos, or AzureAD).
4. Close the ticket in the service-desk system, adding a summary of the actions taken: password reset via SSPR, VPN/Wi-Fi connection established, stale credentials cleared from Credential Manager, and successful logon confirmed.
5. If the user reports any lingering issues (e.g., repeated prompts for credentials, MFA failures), proceed to escalation.

When to escalate

If after completing the self-help and service-desk steps the user still cannot log on, or the account becomes locked out despite correct credentials, escalate to the Identity & Access Management (IAM) team. Provide the following details: user's employee ID and Azure AD UPN, timestamp of the failed logon attempts, SSPR ticket number or password-reset confirmation ID, MFA method used during VPN connection, any error codes shown (e.g., 0x8009030D, 0xC000006A), and a screenshot of the Credential Manager entries that were removed. IAM will investigate potential replication delays between Azure AD and on-prem AD, check for stale password hash synchronization, and issue a Temporary Access Pass if needed.

Keywords: password reset, cached credentials, VPN login, Credential Manager, SSPR, Windows logon failure, domain password sync, GlobalProtect, ACME-Corp Wi-Fi, account lockout, temporary access pass